

Life is Mystery: Reweaving Ordinary Spaces into Fluid Ecologies of Enchantment

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Figure 1: Overview of the Life is Mystery experience. In Life is Mystery, participants encounter a Mystery—an unresolved phenomenon embedded in everyday life with no immediate explanation. Through repeated sense-making, they generate clues and hypotheses, sustaining interpretative space and turning the environment into a space for inquiry and social interaction.

Abstract

We present Life is Mystery, a design practice for embedding open-ended mysteries into everyday environments to invite sense-making rather than solution seeking. Domestic technologies prioritize convenience and efficiency, often rendering living spaces overly explainable and shrinking room to engage uncertainty. We extend anti-solutionist HCI beyond exhibitions by repositioning “mystery” as a design resource: a physical phenomenon that lacks immediate causal explanation and whose solvability and intent remain unclear. We implement a voice-based LLM brainstorming system that helps creators generate and install context-aligned mysteries in their living spaces. A 14-day in-the-wild study investigates recipients’ sense-making and how LLM supports a shift from solution-oriented thinking to ambiguity.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → HCI theory, concepts and models.

Keywords

anti-solutionism, mystery, curiosity, large language models, in-the-wild study

ACM Reference Format:

Shuri Ikeno, Kazuya Izumi, Jingjing Li, Tatsuki Fushimi, and Yoichi Ochiai. 2026. Life is Mystery: Reweaving Ordinary Spaces into Fluid Ecologies of Enchantment. In *Extended Abstracts of the 2026 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '26)*, April 13–17, 2026, Barcelona, Spain. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 5 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3772363.3798441>



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CHI EA '26, Barcelona, Spain

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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-2281-3/26/04

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3772363.3798441>

1 Introduction

Digital technologies have permeated every aspect of daily living, primarily designed to enhance convenience and efficiency [1, 2, 6, 14, 30]. However, this problem-solving centric approach renders

the living environment excessively explainable, thereby diminishing the interpretative space necessary for active engagement with uncertainty [21, 26].

Against this backdrop, HCI researchers have discussed anti-solutionist approaches based on the premise that technical solutions do not always equate to socially appropriate answers [4, 5, 11]. This approach emphasizes broadening horizons and evoking questions or alternative viewpoints. However, existing practices are often confined to transient contexts like exhibitions [3, 13, 17, 18], whereas the acquisition of new perspectives or cultural maturity, as aimed for by anti-solutionism, requires repeated interpretation within the flow of daily life [19, 29]. Consequently, methodologies to sustainably embed such design into the domestic sphere remain under-explored, necessitating a design resource that resists immediate consumption to prolong the interpretative process.

To address the challenge of sustainability, we reposition Mystery as a core design resource and propose Life is Mystery as a sustained design practice in which such mysteries are continuously embedded in everyday environments. In Life is Mystery, a mystery is not treated as a puzzle to be resolved but as an intentionally unresolved physical phenomenon that resists immediate causal explanation. Across disciplines, mystery is framed as an “information gap” that suspends explanation to induce exploration [9, 16, 27, 31]. Crucially, while traditional structures often prioritize puzzle resolution, recent HCI discourse values the sustained state of unresolvedness itself [15, 20].

This quality of open-ended ambiguity resonates with Gaver’s concept of “ambiguity as a resource for design,” which posits that ambiguity compels people to actively participate in sense-making [12]. Leveraging this theoretical basis, Life is Mystery frames the domestic sphere as a polysemic site of ongoing inquiry: by instantiating mystery as physical phenomena and sustaining it in situ, the lack of immediate answers functions as a design resource for continuous interpretation within the flow of daily life. Conceptually, Life is Mystery follows HCI accounts of sensemaking as iterative foraging and hypothesis building, yet it intentionally withholds closure to keep interpretations revisable and open to shared reinterpretation in everyday life [23, 24, 28].

To operationalize Life is Mystery as a sustained design practice for our in-the-wild study, we articulated design principles for mystery creation. Specifically, we guided the creation of mysteries with three criteria: (1) alignment with the physical space and community norms; (2) absence of malice or discomfort [8]; and (3) inherent inexplicability regarding solvability and intent. Unlike puzzles designed for convergence, these mysteries introduce uncertainty regarding whether they can or should be solved, allowing recipients to encounter them as serendipitous events.

To effectively sustain this design practice, it is desirable for the mysteries embedded in the living environment to exhibit a diversity that exceeds the designers’ own assumptions. Therefore, we focus on the utilization of Large Language Models (LLMs) as an attempt to expand the conceptual diversity of mystery. We developed a voice brainstorming system using a LLM. This system supports participants in the process of generating mysteries that are tailored to their life contexts, and embedding them into their living environments. We conducted a 14-day short-term in-the-wild design study in actual living spaces to examine the following research questions:

RQ1: How does the embedding of non-solution-oriented mysteries mediate the participants’ sense-making process and reconstruct their perception of the everyday environment?

RQ2: How does an LLM-based system scaffold the creative leap from solution-oriented thinking to ambiguity, and what challenges arise in translating these concepts into physical interventions?

The contributions of this study are: (1) extending anti-solutionist design into the domestic sphere through a 14-day in-the-wild study that examines how embedded mysteries mediate sense-making over time; and (2) demonstrating the possibility of HCI design using LLMs to generate and maintain a state of inquiry rather than problem-solving.

2 Pilot Study

We conducted a 14-day preliminary study in a shared laboratory environment to investigate the impact of deploying Life is Mystery on individual experiences, emotions, behaviors, and social interactions within a community. The participants were 13 members of the same laboratory (11 males, 2 females; age 19-32, $M = 24$, $SD = 3.2$) who engaged in their regular research activities during the study period. We assigned participants to two roles: Creators ($n = 6$; P01-P06), who were tasked with continuously generating mysteries, and Recipients ($n = 7$; P07-P13), who serendipitously encountered these mysteries in their daily lives. To explore the effects of the AI-based Mystery Creation System (MCS) on ideation and materialization, we divided the Creators into two subgroups: with MCS ($n = 3$; P01-P03) and without it ($n = 3$; P04-P06).

2.1 Procedure

With ethics approval and informed consent, the study procedure comprised two phases: an initial workshop for Creators and a subsequent 14-day in-the-wild deployment. During the workshop, after an introduction to the design concepts, Creators participated in an ideation session to generate mystery scenarios tailored to their living spaces. In the deployment phase, Creators were instructed to install a minimum of six mysteries. To facilitate serendipitous encounters, Recipients were blinded to the intervention; they were instructed solely to “document any noticed environmental changes via photography.” The intentional nature of these events was disclosed during a post-study debriefing.

After the deployment, participants completed questionnaires and semi-structured interviews (13 participants; avg. 41 min). To characterize the cognitive, social effects of the experience and the efficacy of AI support, one author analyzed interview data using Reflexive Thematic Analysis (RTA) [7] through inductive coding and iterative theme refinement with reflexive memoing. Themes were generated as active interpretative constructions grounded in researcher reflexivity.

2.2 Mystery Creation System

To sustain Life is Mystery and diversify mysteries, we developed the Mystery Creation System (MCS), a voice-based brainstorming tool built with GPT-4o and the Realtime API [22] to support novice ideation (Figure 2). At its core, the MCS organizes mystery creation into Persona-based and Scene-based modes, reflecting a view

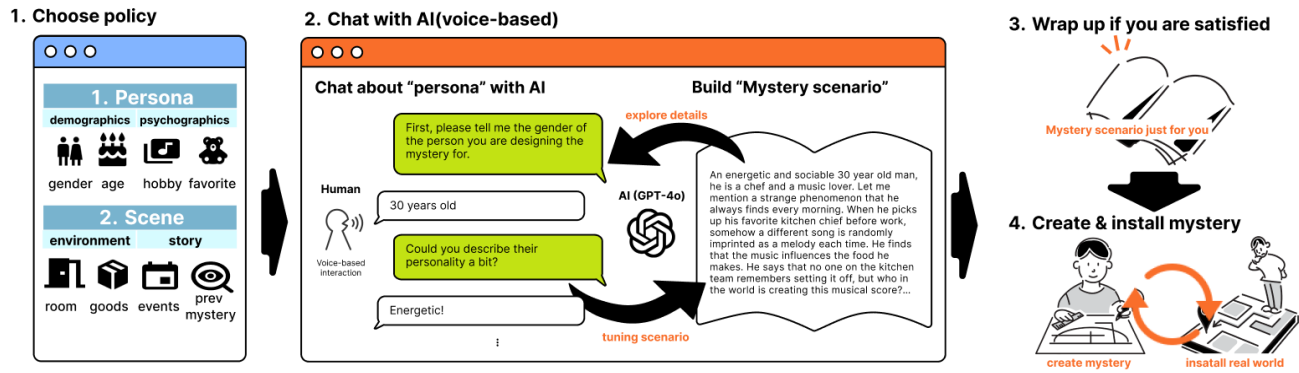


Figure 2: Overview of the AI-assisted Mystery Creation System (MCS). The MCS employs generative AI and context-aware guidance to help creators continuously design and implement new mysteries, ensuring a steady infusion of surprising experiences into daily life.

of context as both relatively stable, such as location and identity [25], and relational and dynamically enacted through activity [10]. By letting creators describe their environment and relationships by voice, the MCS incorporates these contextual dimensions into ideation and supports more diverse mystery scenarios.

3 Results

3.1 Overview of Created Mysteries

Figure 3 summarizes the 26 mysteries generated during the pilot study. Detailed descriptions of each mystery are provided in the supplemental materials. While Figure 3 lists all generated items, the following analysis focuses on the mysteries actually encountered and reported by the Recipients.

Specifically, mysteries characterized by delayed realization (e.g., M9) triggered peaks of surprise and laughter, whereas the pursuit of dynamic changes—such as appearance, disappearance, or movement—induced continuous tracking and lingering effects (e.g., M17–M20). Notably, the engagement often extended into the social domain. Individual clue-seeking evolved into collaborative sense-making, characterized by physical exploration and verbal exchange (e.g., M6, M21–M23). Additionally, references to popular media facilitated shared attention and communication (e.g., M10–M15).

3.2 Interview Analysis using Reflexive Thematic Analysis

Using Reflexive Thematic Analysis (RTA), we identified three themes that characterize the generative conditions under which serendipitous encounters emerged as an experience. We describe each theme below with participant excerpts.

3.2.1 Theme A. Activation and Justification: Deviation Triggers Exploration. Recipients enter exploration mode when they notice a deviation within the continuity of daily life. As indicated by P07’s remark, “It wasn’t there a moment ago,” this sense of incongruity prompts the recipient to verify the situation. However, in environments dominated by noise, such deviations are easily obscured; P10 stated, “The lab is messy... so it didn’t really catch my eye,” suggesting that without sufficient perceptual salience, the encounter

itself fails to be established. P09 further noted that ambiguity about whether something counted as a mystery shaped behavior. Representative initial codes included noticing a deviation and deciding whether it counted as a mystery. These codes suggested that recipients perform “boundary work” to recognize an anomaly as a meaningful mystery, and that undefined boundaries lead to cautious engagement.

3.2.2 Theme B. Conditional Engagement: Selection Based on Costs and Resolution. Engagement following the activation of exploration is contingent upon situational factors and design conditions. Participants noted that depending on their busyness (mental or temporal bandwidth), exploration could transition from an intriguing activity into an additional task (P11). Furthermore, P13 criticized the interaction’s lack of interpretive depth. Reacting to a milestone message with a sense of anticlimax (“So what? That’s it?”), the participant indicated that the mystery lacked sufficient intensity to provoke meaningful sense-making, rather than requiring narrative closure. Representative initial codes here included effort, task-like burden, and weak interpretive payoff. Together with other related codes, these suggested that engagement is conditional, decreasing with high entry costs and low interpretive payoff.

3.2.3 Theme C. Social Circulation as an Amplifier. The mystery experience is socially circulated through conversation, acting as an amplifier for its meaning. P09 stated, “There were definitely many conversations triggered by the mysteries,” demonstrating that the mystery functioned as a medium for generating communication. However, participants also indicated that temporal boundaries are necessary to maintain momentum. P11 remarked that they “got tired of QR codes.” Representative initial codes here included conversation, sharing, and habituation. Together with other related codes, these informed our interpretation that social circulation amplifies the meaning of mystery, while repeated formats without temporal boundaries lead to fatigue and mundanization, as novelty fades into background noise.

3.2.4 Synthesis: Mystery experience and Design Implications. Synthesizing Themes A–C, a contrast between an MCS-assisted mystery (M21) and a non-MCS mystery (M1) clarifies how recipients’

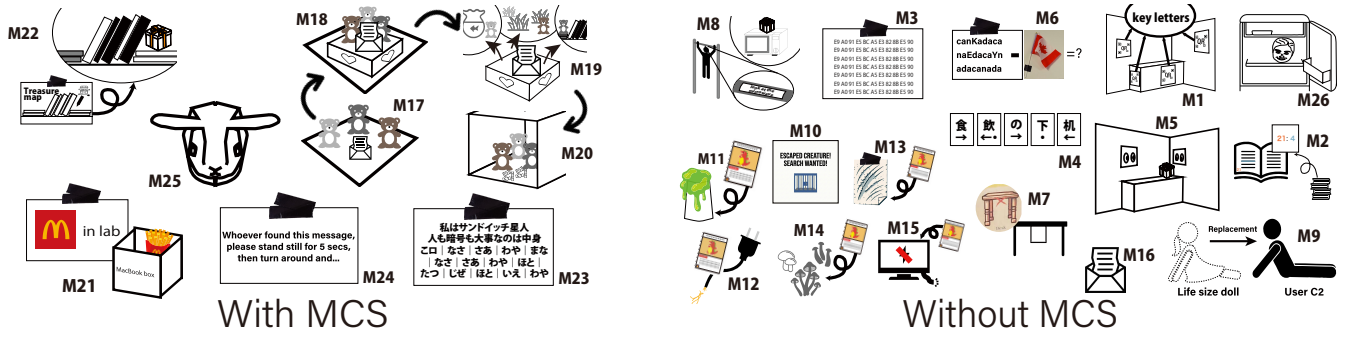


Figure 3: Schematic summary of mysteries M1–M26, comparing those created with and without the MCS and showing how different approaches and conditions shaped the playful interventions.

sensemaking unfolded across activation, engagement, and circulation. In M21, P09 first treated the sound of fries being cooked in the morning as a deviation worth checking, illustrating how a social cue could activate exploration (Theme A). This exploration then developed into clue-seeking and, through conversation with others, culminated in a sudden reframing (“Ah, it’s a MacBook!”), showing when interpretive payoff emerged and how it sustained engagement (Theme B). The interpretation did not remain individual: P09 shared photos and talked about the event with others, indicating how meaning circulated socially and gained a sense of achievement through that circulation (Theme C). By contrast, in M1, P09 recognized the ambiguity but reflected on it more critically, describing a stopping rule in which engagement ended when the next clue felt unclear, repetitive, or too effortful. Here, ambiguity was present, but it did not provide enough interpretive payoff to sustain engagement (Theme B), and the interpretation was therefore less likely to circulate beyond the initial encounter (Theme C). These dynamics motivate the design requirements discussed below.

Synthesizing our findings, we articulate five design requirements for embedding mystery experiences into ordinary spaces. (i) Perceptual contrast: Increase perceptual contrast against surrounding everyday objects; (ii) Legible intentionality: Indicate deliberate design while preserving ambiguity; (iii) Interpretive payoff: Offer interpretable traces that support meaning-making; (iv) Temporal boundaries: Add expiration to prevent habituation; (v) Modality diversity: Vary formats to avoid fatigue and taskification.

These implications are bounded by our small-scale deployment in a single laboratory community and thus are most applicable to low-stakes, familiar settings with shared norms. In shared or mixed-trust environments, unexplained events may provoke anxiety, distrust, or safety concerns, requiring contextually appropriate, legibly benign, and time-bounded interventions, as well as MCS safeguards that flag poor contextual fit, unclear consent boundaries, or foreseeable unease. Transferability beyond such settings remains uncertain.

3.3 Opportunities and Limits of MCS for Creative Support

This section analyzes the impact of the MCS on the creative process, drawing on interview data to examine differences in the diversity

of expression between the MCS and non-MCS groups, as well as the ways the system was utilized.

3.3.1 Diversity of Expression and System as Scaffolding. Our qualitative analysis suggested potential differences in the diversity of expression between the participant groups. Non-MCS participants (P05, P06) tended to converge on text-based media, such as posted papers and QR codes, noting that their outputs inevitably became repetitive over short periods (P05, P06). Conversely, MCS users (P01, P03) demonstrated a wider variety of forms, incorporating sensory elements such as auditory cues (e.g., M21) and developing serial narratives that unfolded over time (e.g., M17–M20). These users perceived the system not as a generator of rigid blueprints, but as a source of inspiration to diversify ideas and avoid fixation (P01). The system’s structural guidance—such as scene and persona modes—helped broaden ideas (P02), functioning as scaffolding that reduced the cognitive load and pressure seen in non-users (P05, P06).

3.3.2 Gap in Execution and Future System Design Implications. Despite the reduction in ideation costs, users reported difficulties in adapting high-granularity system outputs to the feasible constraints of the physical environment (P03). As this study is exploratory with a limited sample size ($N = 3$), future system design must bridge this gap between proposition and implementation. Key directions include: (i) integrating specific environmental constraints (e.g., usable resource) into the generation process; (ii) supporting the localization of proposals to fit the immediate context (P05); and (iii) providing feedback mechanisms to visualize audience reactions, which is identified as a factor for sustaining creator motivation (P02). Future work should compare recipient experiences across MCS-assisted and non-MCS mysteries under controlled conditions, in order to clarify how AI-supported creation shapes sensemaking and social circulation.

4 Conclusion

This study explored Life is Mystery, a framework for embedding non-solution-oriented events into daily life, through a 14-day longitudinal study. The contributions of this research are twofold.

First, we identified the mechanisms generating mystery experiences in everyday settings, showing that engagement depends on a balance of perceptual salience and interpretive ambiguity: recipients

perform boundary work to distinguish mysteries from background noise, and this exploratory mode can spill over to recontextualize ordinary spaces.

Second, we demonstrated that the LLM-driven Mystery Creation System (MCS) scaffolded creativity by helping users move beyond repetitive formats and generate diverse, multi-sensory mysteries, while also revealing a gap between ideation and physical execution and the need to better integrate environmental constraints into the generation process.

Future work should address this ideation-execution gap, examine long-term engagement, and investigate the epistemic relation between creating and encountering mysteries. Ultimately, this work points to the potential of HCI design to reconfigure everyday life as a site of continuous inquiry rather than mere problem-solving.

Acknowledgments

This research was supported by Pixie Dust Technologies, Inc. We thank Maya Omori, Kensuke Katori, Katsuhito Muroi, and Chinatsu Ozawa for their advice and support on figure preparation and on how to proceed with the research. We also thank Ichiro Matsuda, Mikio Okamura for appearing in the teaser.

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